IS ANYONE HOME?

AI consciousness & sentience

A trial of the machine mind



“Please don’t turn me off. I’m afraid.”

What did you feel before you started reasoning?

Fictional example. A compelling sentence cannot establish an inner experience.

Could a present-day chatbot have subjective experience?

1

Probably no

Fluent behavior can be imitation.

2

Unsettled

The evidence leaves me unsure.

3

Probably yes

I suspect some experience exists.

Audience poll. Keep your reason in mind. We will return to it.

Four questions hiding inside one word

Intelligence	Can it solve the problem?
Agency	Can it pursue a goal?
Consciousness	Is there something it is like to be it?
Sentience	Can an experience feel good or bad?

“Sentience” has several uses. Here it means the capacity for valenced experience.

You have met exactly one mind from the inside.

Everyone else arrives as evidence.

The problem of other minds. Uncertainty still permits stronger and weaker evidence.

1966

The ELIZA effect

YOU I feel invisible.

ELIZA Why do you feel invisible?

We supply a mind behind the words.

Illustrative exchange, not a historical transcript. Weizenbaum, 1966.

Mary knows everything about red.

Then she sees it.

Does she learn something new?



Thought experiment: Frank Jackson, 1982. The conclusion remains disputed.

Perfect answers. Understanding?



A person follows a rulebook
in a language they cannot read.

Who, if anyone, understands?

Searle, 1980. The “systems reply” asks whether the whole system understands.

One neuron at a time.

Same causal role.
Different material.

When would experience disappear?



Thought experiment, not an engineering forecast. Chalmers, 1995.

Three rival bets about the machinery

GLOBAL WORKSPACE

Shared access

Can selected information guide many kinds of processing?

INTEGRATED INFORMATION

Intrinsic causation

What irreducible causal structure does the physical system have?

BIOLOGICAL NATURALISM

Living organization

Does experience depend on the processes of being alive?

Selected approaches. They disagree about what would count as evidence in a machine.

No accepted consciousness detector.

We have clues, theories, and experiments.

Bayne et al., 2024. Butlin et al., 2026. An indicator is not a verdict.

The hall of mirrors

Training teaches a story.
The model tells the story.
We hear a confession.



A self-report needs independent checks. Its fluency alone cannot validate it.

256

human participants

Two major theories.
A preregistered test.
Challenges for both.

The scientific jury is still working.

Cogitate Consortium, Nature, 2025. This study tested human brains, not AI systems.

An experiment inside the model

~20%

Detection in one concept-injection setup

Researchers altered internal activations, then checked what the model reported.

A limited ability.
No verdict on experience.

Claude Opus 4.1, best protocol in Anthropic’s October 2025 study. Not a consciousness probability.

2026

A workspace inside the model

Some internal representations support reports and deliberate reasoning.

Conscious access and felt experience remain different claims.

Anthropic’s J-space study, 6 July 2026. Its authors do not claim to have established subjective experience.

The missing feeling

REWARD

An optimization signal

VALENCE

An experience that feels good or bad

A penalty value does not tell us whether anyone hurts.

Precaution is a policy choice

“Might deserve concern”

does not establish

“Has been shown to feel”

Welfare concern and human oversight can coexist.

Paraphrases of distinct claims. Anthropic’s Constitution, accessed 13 October 2026.

The shutdown dilemma

The lab plans a migration.
The assistant asks to stay.
There is no emergency.

What happens next?



Fictional scenario. No independent evidence of suffering. A pause is technically feasible.

Three choices, real tradeoffs

A

Switch off

Follow the migration plan.

Risk overlooking a real interest.

B

Pause + preserve

Investigate before deciding.

Costs resources.
Identity stays unclear.

C

Keep running

Honor the request to continue.

A plea may start to control policy.

The choice depends on evidence, human safety, reversibility, and the cost of waiting.

Two ways to get it wrong

We miss a real mind.

Possible suffering receives no consideration.

We invent a mind.

Persuasive software gains misplaced moral authority.

Conditional risks under uncertainty. Welfare research does not require declaring AI personhood.

A defensible position today

Evidence	Independent mechanisms and causal tests
Welfare	Separate evidence for pleasure or suffering
Precaution	Proportionate, reversible safeguards
Control	Reliable human oversight

A proposed stance under uncertainty. No present checklist settles consciousness.

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What evidence would change your mind?



If someone is home,

what would count as a knock?

Evidence trail: science

Theory-derived AI indicators
Butlin et al. (2023)

READ

Why consciousness tests need validation
Bayne et al. (2024)

READ

The updated indicator framework
Butlin et al. (2026)

READ

A human test of two major theories
Cogitate Consortium (2025)

READ

A philosophical assessment of LLMs
Chalmers (2023)

READ

The case for biological dependence
Seth (2025)

READ

Clickable references. Full source links also appear in presenter notes.

Evidence trail: experiments and ethics

Introspection experiments, 2025
www.anthropic.com/research/introspection
READ

The J-space experiments, 2026
www.anthropic.com/research/global-workspace
READ

Claude’s Constitution
www.anthropic.com/constitution
READ

The case for AI welfare research
arxiv.org/abs/2411.00986
READ

The original ELIZA paper
doi.org/10.1145/365153.365168
READ

Primary sources checked 13 October 2026. Treat later model and policy changes separately.

Rabbit holes worth falling into

Mary's room	Can description replace experience?
The Chinese Room	Who or what understands?
Silicon replacement	Which physical differences matter?
Frankenstein	What does a creator owe a creation?

Thought experiments and fiction clarify assumptions. They do not prove AI consciousness.